

ing from the cold swathes of Europe. Says Lalsinh Raol, a Gujarat-based ornithologist, "Porbandar should rank as one of the topmost places for bird diversity in the Indian subcontinent. What's more, many of these migratory species have also begun to breed in Porbandar."

Porbandar figures in a book *Birds of Saurashtra*, penned by renowned bird watcher and the late prince of Bhavnagar, Dharmendrakumar-sinhji. As early as in 1970, European ornithologist Peter Jackson was fascinated by the bird wealth of Porbandar after he saw flamingoes from just 10 ft away in the city's main lake. His efforts were instrumental in

the region being declared a bird sanctuary. "One reason may be the Government's multi-fold water conservation measures like check dams, filling up of sweet water bodies and bringing water to ponds and lakes from bigger water bodies."

Another reason may be the change in the migratory pattern from birds coming in from the winter cold of Europe, seeking warmer climes. According to ornithologists, Porbandar has always been on the flight path of migratory birds coming to India from Europe and Central Asia. One of their destinations is the wetlands of the Sindh. Porbandar, with its ample sweet and saline water, food like in-

watching camps for them.

The area's bird wealth is staggering. During October-March, the Amipur lake alone was visited by 80,000 Demoiselle cranes from Europe and Siberia and about 20,000 common cranes. The Kuchdi lake near Porbandar and Meda creek, about 45 km distant, are also magnets for migratory birds. Among the rare birds in large numbers at Porbandar this season is the Golden Blower that can fly non-stop for 3,000 km, Black-Neck Stork, Hobara Bustard and the Great Crested Grebe besides falcon-like prey species like the Marsh Harrier, Peregrine Falcon and Greater Spotted Eagle. There are

PORBANDAR HAS SEVERAL WATER BODIES TO CATER TO ITS WINGED GUESTS



Port of Call

How Gandhi's birthplace became the new birdland:

- More water bodies due to good rains over past eight years and good surface water management.
- Being on the coast, it offers both sweet and saline surface water to birds.
- Possible changes in migratory route of birds coming from Europe and Central Asia.
- Increase in production of pulses which attract diverse bird species.

getting the lake declared a bird sanctuary. Today, it is the smallest bird sanctuary of Gujarat, spread over just 9.33 hectares. Porbandar has two other lakes that are also a haven for birds. In fact, after the famous Lake Nakuru in Africa, Porbandar is one of the few places in the world where flamingoes can be seen at close distance.

Most bird watchers agree, however, that the number of birds being spotted here are on a stunning rise. Says Siddharth Khandekar, a recent entrant as a bird watcher who has prepared a bird conservation plan for

sects, fish and cultivation of pulses, makes it a much-favoured stop.

Bharat Rughani, a bird watcher who heads the Porbandar chapter of the Bird Conservation Society of Gujarat, says, "Only a detailed and scientific study can find out the precise factors behind this phenomenon. It is possible that the numbers have increased because Porbandar has received massive rains in recent years, creating new and plentiful water bodies." Rughani is now working to spread awareness about Porbandar's birds among the local students by organising bird-

also globally endangered species like Spoonbill Sandpiper, numbering just a few thousand in the world and the Slender Bill Curlew.

At the behest of bird enthusiasts, fishing has already been banned in parts of the Gosabara dam. They are also seeking to extend the conservation cover for the feathered creatures and are trying to have Porbandar declared a bird city, if not a sanctuary. For the birds winging their way in from thousands of miles away, the late Mahatma's former home may well be another homecoming. ■